

LUKE LARSEN

SCOTT GILBERTSON

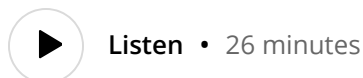
GEAR MAY 28, 2026 7:01 AM

How to Choose the Right Laptop: A Step-by-Step Guide

Shopping for a laptop can be infuriating. Here's how to sift through the acronyms, storage options, and extra features to find the best one for you.



All products featured on WIRED are independently selected by our editors. However, we may receive compensation from retailers and/or from purchases of products through these links. [Learn more.](#)



MOST PEOPLE WILL be happy just buying the latest MacBook Air—and I'm happy for them. But you're not most people. You want to know that your money isn't being wasted, or that you aren't missing out on the latest and greatest technological innovation. Or maybe you're just wondering what's changed in the past five years since you last bought a laptop.

Good news—that's how my brain works too. And I've been testing laptops for well over a decade now, including all the major releases so far in 2026. Feel free to skip around, but if you have a question about a laptop or a particular aspect of a laptop, you've come to the right place.

Updated May 2026: We've added the latest chip news from Intel, AMD, Apple, and Qualcomm. We also have details on changes in pricing, the memory shortage, the latest MacBooks, and the future of Chromebooks.

Table of Contents



- [Understanding Use Cases and Budget](#)
- [Which Operating System Is Best?](#)
- [Understanding Processor Names \(CPUs\)](#)
- [How Much Processing Power Do You Need?](#)
- [What About a Graphics Card?](#)
- [How Much RAM Do You Need?](#)

- [Webcams, Hinges, and More](#)
 - [Make Your Choice](#)
 - [Where to Buy](#)
-

Understanding Use Cases and Budget

Before getting into the nitty-gritty, I always recommend starting with the biggest question first: What will you do with your new laptop? Is this a business machine meant primarily for office work and other simple tasks that can be done in a browser? Or perhaps you have a burgeoning interest in a hobby like PC gaming, video editing, coding, or design. Maybe one of those hobbies is more of a job for you, meaning you'll want something that is designed from the ground up to accelerate work in those applications. On the other side of the spectrum, maybe you plan to primarily use your laptop on the go, whether that's on a plane or in coffee shops. In that case, portability and battery life may be the most important factors to consider.

The answer to those questions will help point you in the right direction and ensure that you don't overspend on features or performance you don't need. For example, buying a [MacBook Pro instead of a MacBook Air](#) just because you have extra money to spend isn't a good idea. Neither is configuring a laptop with a faster processor with less memory. And all that brings me to the budget: \$1,000 is an important price. There are many good options below that price, but it's the level at which you can expect laptops to feel premium and lack significant compromises. It's the starting retail price of the starting [MacBook Air](#), as well as several [Windows laptops](#). That's not to say that there aren't many cheap laptops these days that are surprisingly solid. In fact, with the launch of the \$599 MacBook Neo earlier this year, we're seeing a surge of competition to create the best laptop at this price.

If your budget is truly only a few hundred bucks, though, you're better off buying a [Chromebook](#) than a bottom-tier Windows laptop. They'll feel faster and lighter, and

Which Operating System Is Best?



COURTESY OF APPLE

I won't waste your time repeating the same arguments you've probably already heard about why macOS is better than Windows, or vice versa. Both have strengths and weaknesses, and you likely already have opinions about them. The truth is that these operating systems are more similar today than they have ever been, not unlike Android and iOS. So if you're on the fence, I recommend opting for a laptop that runs whichever is most familiar.

ADVERTISEMENT

For some people, however, it might be helpful to think through what software you need to run, and which operating systems it runs best on, which will help you determine the hardware you need. And let's not forget: ChromeOS and Linux are still alternative options. So, here's how the four available operating systems break down.

Windows

Windows is the stalwart default OS. Windows is the broadest and most widely used operating system, supporting the largest number of applications and hardware. Your workplace may require it, or maybe you need it to run a specific app. Every new Windows laptop released in the past few years comes with the latest Windows 11. Due to its comparatively open nature, new laptops arrive throughout the year, ranging from [cheap laptops](#) to blinged-out [gaming laptops](#). There is even a variety of [2-in-1 laptops](#) to consider, with adventurous designs and integrated touchscreens. Regardless of your budget, you'll have an easier time finding something in the Windows ecosystem that works for you. Since 2024, Microsoft has been pushing Copilot AI features deeper and deeper into the operating system, but in 2026, that direction may be reversing—or at least slowing down. Its upcoming 2026 update scheduled for later this year will focus more on improving performance, removing Copilot clutter, and adding more customization to the Taskbar.

an iPhone. But it's tightly coupled with the company's hardware, meaning your buying options are limited to MacBooks. Since Apple uses its own chips, and MacBooks are a different beast altogether, we have a separate [guide to picking the best MacBook](#). If you're already bought into the Apple ecosystem with iPhones or iPads, MacBooks have several software features (such as AirDrop and Universal Control) that are legitimately convenient, and Apple makes some of the best laptop hardware in the game. The last major release of the operating system, [macOS 26 Tahoe](#), officially launched last fall, which brought a new visual design, updates to Spotlight, and much more.

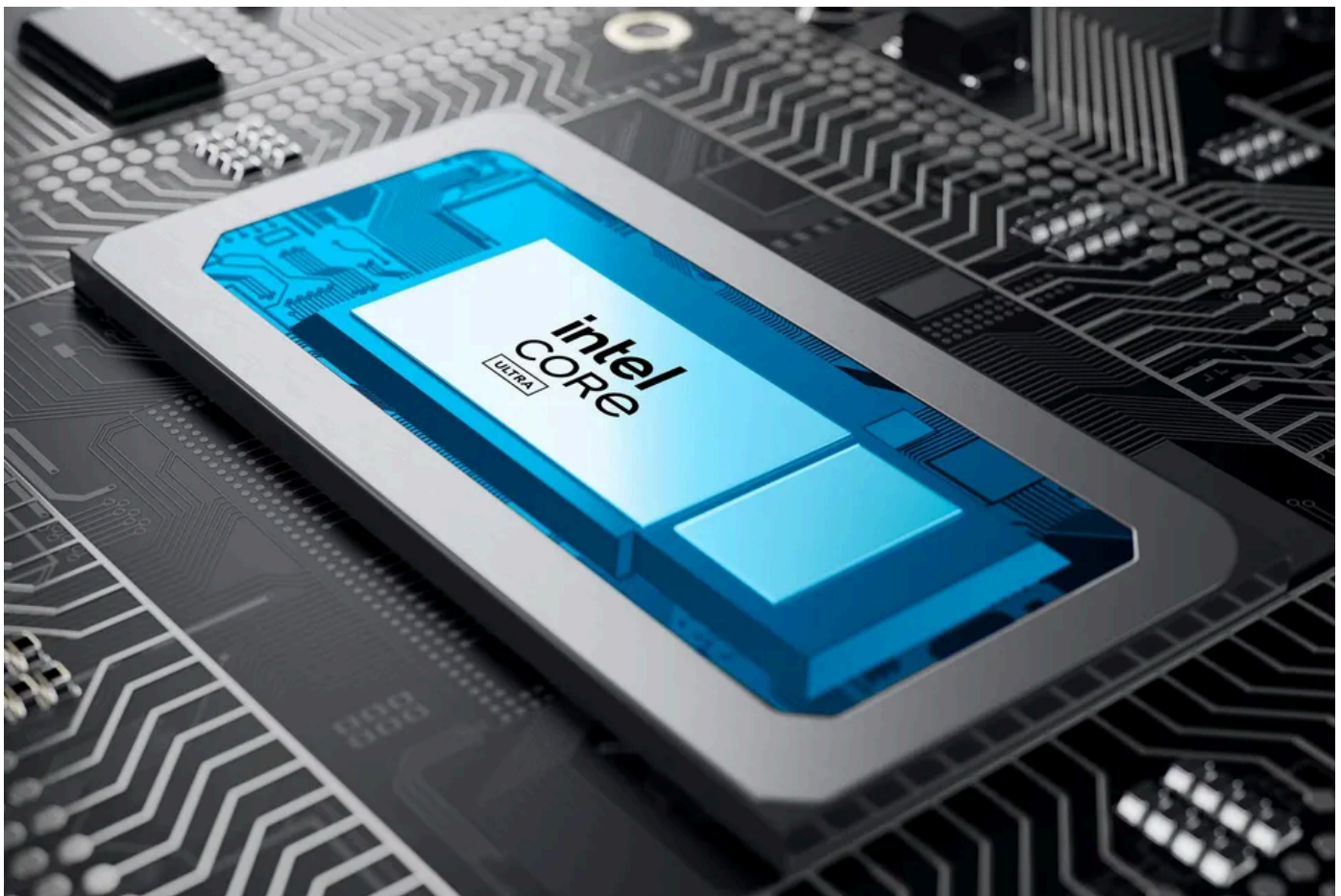
ChromeOS

If you can do most of your laptop tasks in a web browser and are trying to save some cash, ChromeOS is a good choice. Chrome laptops (called Chromebooks) are also among the cheapest (and least powerful) you'll find, so the OS is also worth considering if you're on a tight budget. Although Chromebooks are most often associated with the dirt-cheap school laptops that are loaned out to high schoolers, they've grown into something more than that. The “Chromebook Plus” designation [rolled out in late 2023](#), a way of emphasizing higher-end Chromebooks that use faster processors, more memory, more storage, and better video cameras, such as on the [Samsung Galaxy Chromebook Plus](#). The same limitations are still there, though. You can't run Adobe's Creative Suite or Microsoft Office. Some apps, notably Office, do have an Android phone/tablet version you *might* be able to [install on your Chromebook](#) (or a web version), but I have found Android apps often don't run well. Google has recently been talking about the future of Chromebooks and Google tablets, confirming that a merging of the two is coming in 2026, first rumored as [Aluminium OS](#) and has since been [revealed as Googlebooks](#). Read our [Best Chromebooks](#) guide for more.

Linux

Windows 11. If you don't need MS Office and don't mind a learning curve, you can install Linux on just about any piece of laptop hardware ever created. Like with ChromeOS, the catch is that popular apps like MS Office and Adobe's Creative Suite don't support Linux. However, there are free, open-source alternatives like LibreOffice, Darktable (Adobe Lightroom replacement), and GIMP (Adobe Photoshop replacement). See our [Best Linux Laptops](#) guide for our favorites.

Understanding Processor Names (CPUs)



COURTESY OF INTEL

Once you know which operating system you want and have some idea of the software you're going to run, you can figure out the minimum hardware specifications you'll need. The first thing we suggest looking at is the processor, also

Intel Processors



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

Intel has had a rough few years, but its offering in 2026 feels quite strong. [Panther Lake](#), built on the long-anticipated 18A node, is the culmination of five years of planning and engineering—and it's largely paid off. I won't get into all the details, but the company is finally executing on CPU performance, GPU performance, and battery life at a scale it's never accomplished before. I saw this most recently when I tested the Dell XPS 14, which was one of the first laptops out of the gate to support Panther Lake. It has the GPU performance you could only get with a discrete graphics card in the past, but it also gets really impressive battery life. That's a combination we've only seen on MacBooks thus far.

numbers), but you could at least always know that the Core i7 was faster than the Core i5. Intel introduced new branding back in 2023, however, which swapped out “Core i5” for “Core Ultra 5.”

With the latest generation of silicon from Intel, the company has once again introduced a change to how the chips are named. You still depend on the “3” at the beginning of the SKU to know what generation you're in, fortunately. But that's only step one. When shopping for the new Dell XPS 14 devices, for example, you're presented with four Intel chip options: Core Ultra 5 325, Core Ultra 7 355, Core Ultra X7 358H, and Core Ultra X9 388H.

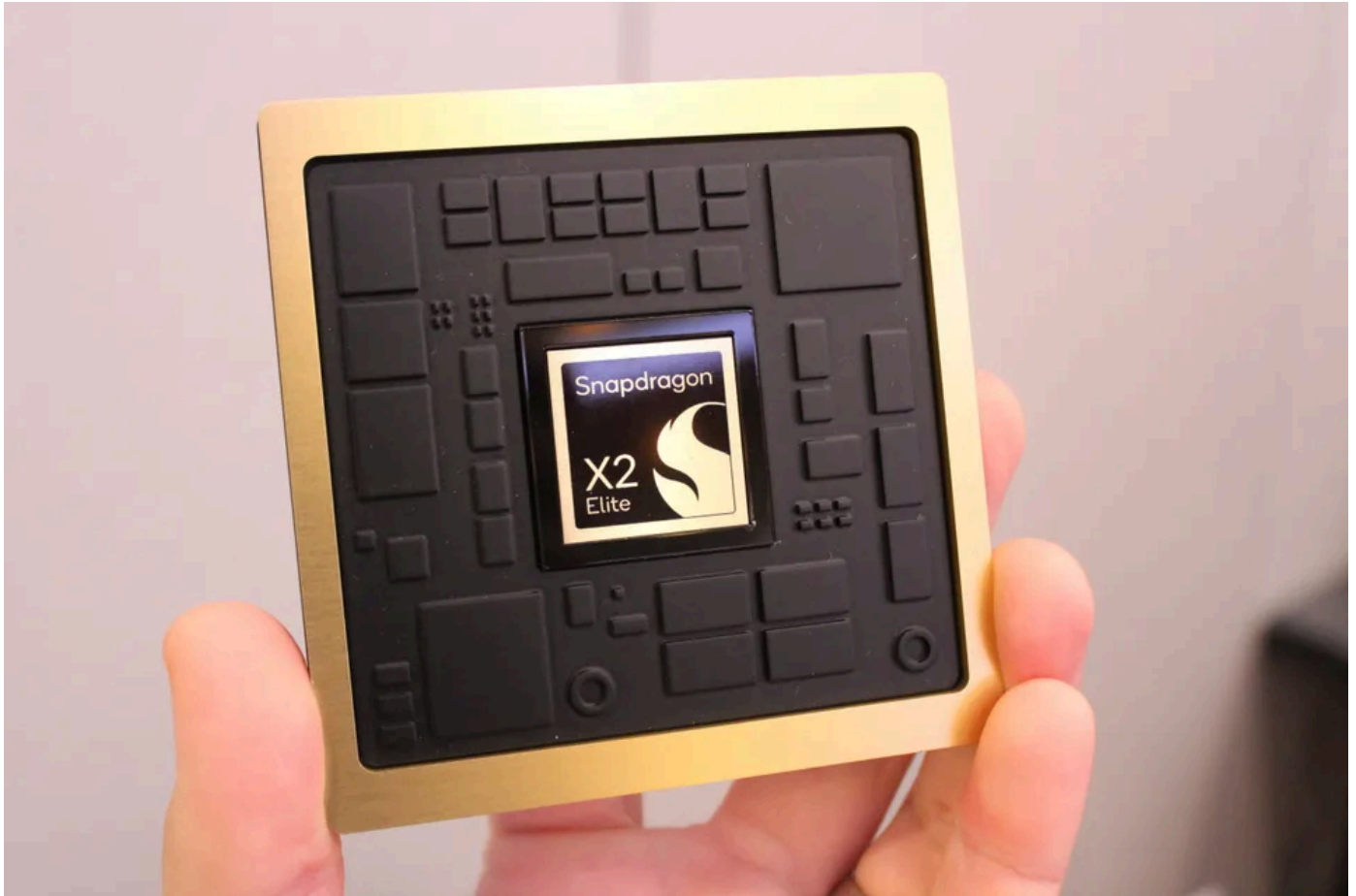
All the H-series chips get you 16 CPU cores, while adding the X7 or X9 modifiers indicates chips with 12 GPU cores. They're the first Intel chips that truly feel like they can compete with what Apple has achieved on the M4 and M5 in terms of integrated graphics performance. You'll notice that the “V” and “U” designations used in the Core Ultra Series 2 are gone, as that distinction is no longer necessary with these new chips, which were all manufactured by Intel.

Brand	Architecture	CPU cores	GPU Cores
H X9	Panther Lake	16 cores	12 cores
H X7	Panther Lake	16 cores	12 cores
H	Panther Lake	16 cores	Up to 10 cores
No letter	Panther Lake	4 cores	4 cores

As always with Intel, there are odd exceptions to allow Windows laptop manufacturers to build and sell unique designs. For example, the Core Ultra 5 338H has only 12 CPU cores but 10 GPU cores, while the Core Ultra 7 356H has 16 CPU cores and only 4 GPU cores. It's not just as simple as all the Core Ultra 7 H variants being faster than the Core Ultra 5 H chips.

today still have a Series 2 chip, such as the Core Ultra 7 258V.

Qualcomm Processors



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

Qualcomm made a huge splash in the Windows laptop space in 2024, debuting the Snapdragon X line of chips and thoroughly disrupting Intel's hold on laptop CPUs. Over the past year, we've tested a number of these laptops and found them to be competitive not only with Intel's latest chips but also with the latest Apple M4 silicon.

serious video editors, gamers, and content creators, but they do all come with an NPU (Neural Processing Unit) capable of 45 TOPS (trillions of operations per second). When they initially launched, these Snapdragon laptops were the only devices that qualified as Copilot+ PCs, as they were the only laptops with the 45-TOPS NPU. These days, however, both Intel and AMD have earned the Copilot+ PC badge.

The major difference with the Snapdragon chips is the ARM architecture. These have been used in phone chips for many years, but Apple showed how they could scale up with the M-series of chips used in MacBooks, while keeping that impressive efficiency. Snapdragon X is the equivalent of that for Windows laptops, finally delivering both performance and battery life. Initially, there were concerns about app compatibility, which has been a problem with ARM adoption in the past. A year later, that's largely been resolved, with most major applications being compiled for ARM natively.

In October 2025, Qualcomm announced the first chips in its next-gen line, Snapdragon X2. So far, there's the Snapdragon X2 Elite and X2 Plus, as well as a new entry in the lineup: the Snapdragon X2 Elite Extreme. Both the X2 Elite and X2 Elite Extreme have options for up to 18 cores, as well as a claimed jump in integrated graphics, which was the weakest point of the first generation. This X2 Elite Extreme has higher frequencies and higher memory bandwidth for better AI workload performance over the X2 Elite. Meanwhile, the NPU takes a big step forward as well, offering 80 TOPS of performance across the entire lineup of Snapdragon X2 chips. The only chip left in the line is the Snapdragon X2, which is its lowest-tier option, reserved for budget laptops. Some of my very favorite cheap laptops to recommend throughout the past year have been the base Snapdragon X laptops.

Like with Intel, though, we're still waiting for these new X2 chips to fully roll out to more devices you can actually go and buy.

AMD Processors

AMD reset its branding as a response to Intel, so we're now on the 3rd generation of chips. Like Intel, you can tell you're looking at the latest chips by the first number in the SKU. AMD uses similar nomenclature to Intel, including Ryzen 5, Ryzen 7, and Ryzen 9. AMD even uses similar family names like HX, H, and U series to indicate different performance and power envelopes. AMD had a couple of unique solutions in 2026, such as the Ryzen AI Max/Max+ chips, as seen in the [Asus ROG Flow Z13](#). These chips use an oversized integrated GPU chip, the Radeon 8060S, which has a whopping 40 GPU cores, effectively eliminating the need for a discrete GPU. I recently tested this in the [Asus TUF Gaming A14](#) and found the results disappointing. Then, there's the Ryzen 9 9955HX3D, which brings the successful 3D V-cache technology to a refreshed Ryzen 9000 chip for gaming laptops.

As you can see, gaming laptops have become a major emphasis for AMD, because it's the one area where AMD has managed to win designs from Intel. Like Intel and Qualcomm, AMD also launched its own next-generation chips earlier this year that use the Zen 6 architecture, but only a few models have reached store shelves yet.

Apple Processors



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

Apple makes several chips these days, used in MacBooks, Macs, iPads, and iPhones. The M-series chips have been a huge hit since 2020, dramatically increasing performance and battery life. Fortunately, the designations are a bit simpler to parse. Each generation of chip is designated by a number, while add-ons like Pro and Max scale up the processing and graphics performance.

The M5 family of chips for MacBooks is the latest release, and with WWDC just next month, we're closer to closing that series. It's come to all versions of the MacBook Pros, the MacBook Air, the iPad Pro, and even the Vision Pro. We're still waiting for the M5 to come to the Mac desktop line. The big surprise this year was the MacBook Neo, however, which launched in March, sporting the A18 Pro chip rather than a traditional Mac chip. This cut helped Apple bring prices down to just \$599, which is the cheapest MacBook the company has ever sold. I won't get into the full details of how this laptop's overall package lands, but the A18 Pro performs better in the Neo than you might assume. Make sure to read my full breakdown of how the MacBook Neo compares to the MacBook Air for more information.

all of this is subject to change. Either way, the M6 has been rumored to make a big splash alongside the upcoming "MacBook Ultra," which brings OLED touchscreens to the Mac for the first time.

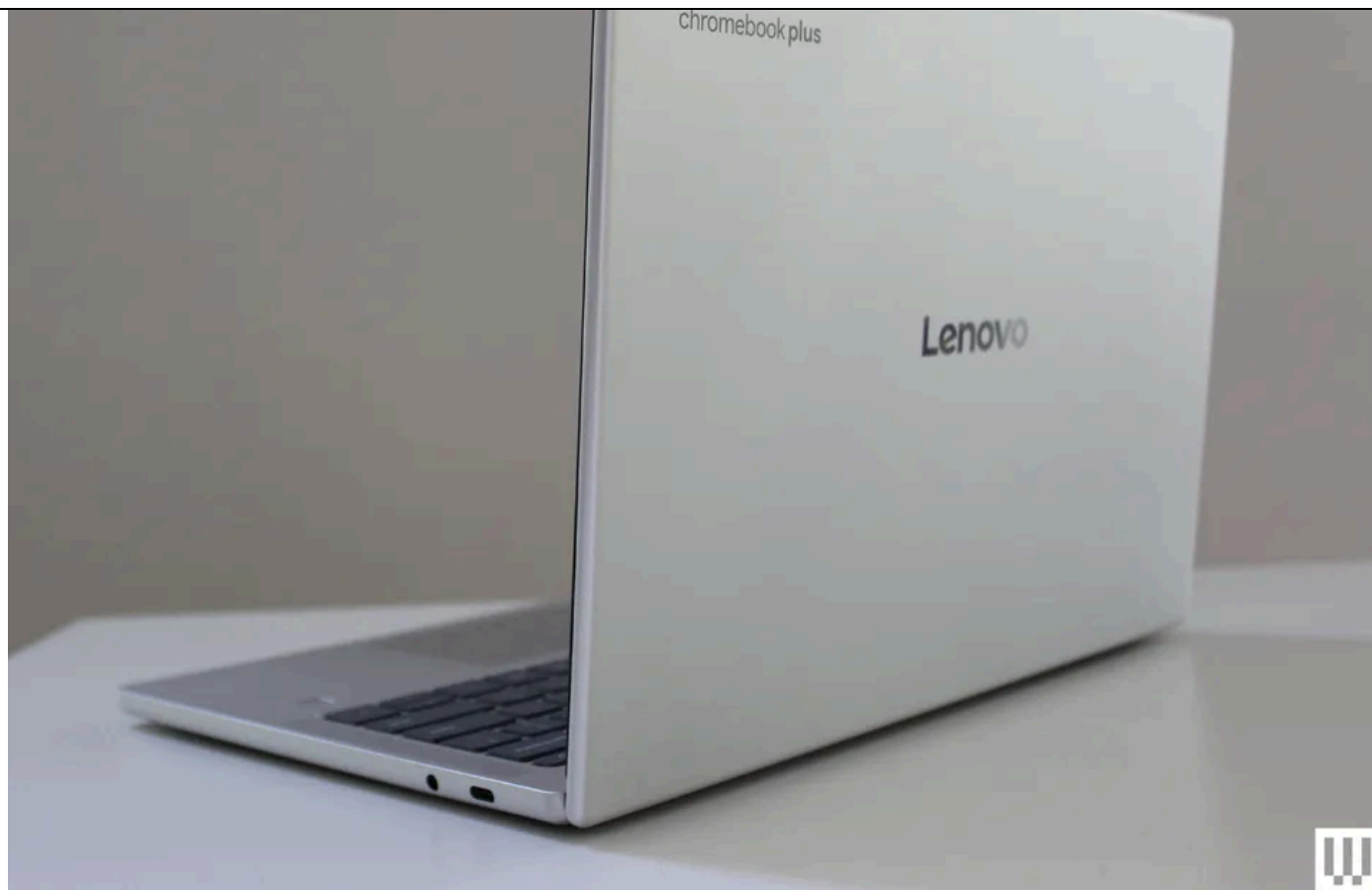
How Much Processing Power Do You Need?

If you're a typical user who runs a web browser, Microsoft's Office Suite, and perhaps some photo editing software, we recommend a laptop with one of Intel's Core Ultra V-series chips, such as the Core Ultra 7 258V. These perform well enough and get great battery life.

There are a few good reasons to go for Qualcomm, however. While battery life on these devices is similar to Intel's latest chips (and Apple's, for that matter), performance doesn't drop as much as Intel's. The prices are also lower, especially on Snapdragon X and X Plus configurations. Laptops are selling for as low as \$799 that use the Snapdragon X. While these don't perform as well as the X Plus or X Elite models, they still get great battery life, which is impressive for a laptop of this price.

If you compile software, edit videos, or work with large databases, you're going to want more processing power than the rest of us. You want either an H-class or HX-class processor from Intel or AMD. You'll also want to get a discrete GPU and load up on RAM, but we'll get to that in a minute.

Best Processors for ChromeOS Laptops



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

ChromeOS is built around Google's Chrome web browser and runs most software directly in the browser. That means it doesn't need big, powerful Intel chips. That's the theory, at least. In my experience, ChromeOS does best with at least an Intel i3 chip or, the best value you can currently get with a Chromebook: an AMD Ryzen 4000 chip. Those, unfortunately, are much harder to find.

In 2023, Google introduced a new class of Chromebook called Chromebook Plus. The “Plus” means these models are more powerful. Most that we've tested have had Intel Core i3 or better, along with more memory, more storage, and better webcams than traditional Chromebooks. The good news is that these are not much more expensive than the older models.

At the other end of the spectrum, there are also an increasing number of Chromebooks with Qualcomm's Snapdragon series chips, which offer a good

Core-series processors. In a similar vein, MediaTek, a chipmaker typically known for low-power options, launched one of the most capable new chips for Chromebooks, the MediaTek Kompanio Ultra 910. This has shown up in two of the best high-end Chromebooks you can buy right now, the [Lenovo Chromebook Plus 14](#) and Acer Chromebook Plus Spin 514, providing great performance and excellent battery life.

The cheapest Chromebooks still use Intel's Celeron series processors. If your needs are very minimal and you'll never do anything more than lightly browse the web, the Celerons will do. But if you're hoping to run Android apps or install Linux apps on your Chromebook, the Celeron processors will struggle and will likely frustrate you.

What About a Graphics Card?



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

All laptops technically have graphics cards, but most are bundled into the motherboard with the processor. This approach, known as “integrated graphics,” is fine for most users. You’ll be able to watch movies and even play casual games without too much of an issue. Intel’s integrated graphics are currently the best, outdoing AMD and Qualcomm’s solutions.

If you’re a gamer or do a lot of video editing, though, you’ll want a laptop with a discrete graphics card—a separate and much more powerful graphics card. AMD and Nvidia are the two options, though Nvidia is the dominant solution. Nvidia rolled out its RTX 50-series graphics cards in 2025, including the [RTX 5090](#), [5080](#), [5070 Ti](#), [5070](#), and [5060](#). These are still the latest and greatest.

If you’re buying a [gaming laptop](#), starting with the RTX 5070 Ti is a good idea, since it gets you 12 GB of VRAM, an increasingly important spec for running new AAA

is multi-frame generation.

Laptops with discrete GPUs tend to struggle with battery life and are quite expensive, but if you really need that performance, it's your best option.

How Much RAM Do You Need?



PHOTOGRAPH: ANMBPH/GETTY IMAGES

The more the merrier! Random-access memory, known as RAM, is what your laptop uses to hold data while the processor does things with it. Think of RAM as your desk. All the things you're working on right now should be able to fit on your desk. If your desk is too small, things fall off, and you can't work on them. In the same way, if you

In the past, 8 GB of RAM was the standard. But since 2024 or so, that standard moved up to 16 GB. With all the on-device AI models that run in the background in both Windows 11 and macOS these days, having more RAM is key to ensuring you didn't hit slowdowns in your work. For Windows, 16 GB is the requirement for qualification as a Copilot+ PC, meaning laptops as cheap as \$799 now come with 16 GB. Because of that, only [budget laptops](#) or Chromebooks should be considered with 8 GB (or less). Some of that has changed with the introduction of the 8-GB MacBook Neo, however. So far, though, that remains more of an outlier.

16 GB is really just the minimum, though—32 GB is a great option for gamers or content creators who are willing to pay for the best performance. Or you can go higher; the highest-end MacBook Pro models and other performance-driven laptops now offer up to 128 GB of memory. That's especially important for those who are interested in running on-device AI models.

One thing to keep in mind is RAM expandability. Many laptops these days don't allow you to upgrade or replace memory yourself. Unless you're buying a [Framework Laptop](#), you'll find that most now come soldered down. That means you'll need to configure your laptop with the amount of RAM you actually need when you buy it. Some gaming laptops are among the rare few that allow you to upgrade or offer a free slot to add a secondary stick of RAM.

Lastly, you'll want to consider memory speed. Laptops you buy in 2026 will have either DDR4 or DDR5 RAM, also known as double data rate. You'll often see this referred to as LPDDR5X, the mobile version of DDR5, made for laptops. This has become common for premium laptops in 2026. The next iteration, DDR6, is supposed to launch in 2027.

There's one problem in all this talk about increasing RAM capacity: [a looming memory shortage](#) caused by increased demand from AI data centers. While laptops

can get 16 GB or 32 GB of RAM in a laptop for an affordable price right now, it's a good time to buy.

How Much Storage Do You Need?



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

The hard drive is where you'll store all your data. Think of this as the filing cabinet next to your desk. Nearly every laptop you can buy these days comes with an NVMe solid-state drive (SSD), which is nothing like the old-school spinning drives of many years ago.

depend on each person. If you primarily use cloud storage and don't need many local applications installed, 256 GB of storage might suit you just fine. Outside of Chromebooks, it's almost unheard of to find laptops with storage capacity as low as 128 GB these days.

If you plan to deal with lots of local files or have lots of games installed, you'll want at least 512 GB of storage. For high-end gaming laptops, for example, 1 TB has become the standard, such as on the [Razer Blade 16](#). The absolute minimum amount of space we recommend is 256 GB, although increasingly, we're seeing 512 GB become the new norm. Even the base MacBook Air [comes with 512 GB at \\$1,099](#). If you store everything in the cloud or are looking at Chromebooks, you might be able to get by with less, but it's good to have the space if you ever need it. If you plan to install games, software, or save a lot of photos or videos, that will quickly eat up space. If you need more, read our [Best Portable SSDs](#) guide for external and internal expansion options.

You may have noticed that your hard drive doesn't seem to ever have its advertised space. If a hard drive is labeled 512 GB, it may show as having only 490 GB available in Windows. You aren't losing space; this just has to do with the difference between binary and decimal byte size calculations. The drive makers use decimal bytes, but Windows uses binary, which is why they report different sizes. They are both technically correct, though the size Windows reports is the amount of disk space you can use to store files.

If you're shopping for a budget laptop, you may run across eMMC storage. This is still billed as an SSD (which it is), but it's a little different than the NVMe and PCIe SSDs. The abbreviation stands for Embedded MultiMediaCard, and it's what you'll find in phones, tablets, and some laptops (especially Chromebooks). However, the "embedded" in eMMC usually means it's soldered directly onto the motherboard. In other words, you can't swap in a larger drive down the road. The other disadvantage is slower speeds.



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

The best place to start here is screen size, since that determines how big a laptop you're getting. In many cases, it also determines the amount of performance you can get out of the laptop. The three most common sizes for laptops are 13-inch, 14-inch, and 16-inch.

Most laptop buyers should start with the 14-inch size, as it's a great compromise between portability, screen real estate, and performance. Some 14-inch laptops can have powerful discrete GPUs, such as the [ROG Zephyrus G14](#) or [Razer Blade 14](#),

15-inch laptops, such as the [Dell XPS 15](#) or [MacBook Air 15-inch](#), are designed to be highly compact and portable. They can feel a little cramped, but they're great for college students or frequent travelers, as they're the most convenient for airplanes, coffee shops, and tossing in your bag. Lastly, there are 16-inch laptops, which are designed primarily for those who need more performance. In addition to having larger screens, they tend to be thicker and allow for more powerful GPUs.

While those are the major categories, occasionally you'll find 15-inch laptops that provide extra screen real estate without a thicker chassis, such as the [15-inch MacBook Air](#) or the [15-inch Surface Laptop](#). Some gaming laptops have moved up to the 18-inch size, which gives you unbridled performance in the largest package possible, though they're cumbersome.



of the screen to consider. Due to the 16:10 aspect ratio, 2560 x 1600 is the default resolution for premium 13-inch or 14-inch laptops. That's true of the MacBook Air, as well as many gaming laptops, providing a high enough pixel density so that you can't see individual pixels. I recommend buying a 15-inch or 16-inch laptop with at least this resolution, while 1920 x 1200 is good enough for more budget-minded 13-inch or 14-inch laptops. There are higher-resolution laptops, which are especially good for larger screens.

The next thing to consider is your screen's capabilities. For example, touchscreens will add to the cost, but they can be useful if you want to sketch on your laptop or take handwritten notes. The refresh rate has also become an important feature. Budget laptops are often at 60 Hz, but increasingly, we're seeing 75, 90, or 120 Hz as the new standard for average premium laptops. Gaming laptops take this to the extreme, with refresh rates up to 240, 360, or even 500 Hz.

We have to talk about the panels themselves. IPS LCD is the standard, but next-generation panels like Mini-LED or OLED are increasingly common. Mini-LED can get much brighter than IPS, such as the MacBook Pro, which can range up to 1,200 nits of peak HDR brightness. OLED panels are readily available in Windows laptops, which don't get as bright in SDR as Mini-LED but have the deep blacks that only OLED can produce, making it great for HDR. These types of displays can cost extra, but lately, you can sometimes get them for under \$1,000.

Check for Ports



PHOTOGRAPH: JULIAN CHOKKATTU

While the CPU, RAM, and storage will have the biggest impact on performance, the amount and types of ports on your laptop are important. Highly portable laptops restrict ports to only USB-C and a headphone jack. Some laptops even ditch the headphone jack.

The most powerful USB-C ports are Thunderbolt 5, which are rolling out on high-end gaming laptops. Thunderbolt 5 adds lots of extra bandwidth, as well as supporting up to 240 watts of power delivery. But for most people, you'll want to make sure you read the details on the USB-C ports if you need support for multiple displays, as some USB-C ports have built-in display output.

Almost all modern laptops can charge via USB-C, which is extremely convenient. This method of charging allows you to use a portable charger if you ever need extra time away from a power outlet. USB-C chargers also tend to be cheaper to replace, and you may already use them to charge your phone. Never buy those cheap, no-name replacement chargers you see on Amazon. Spend extra and buy the manufacturer's charger or a known brand. I have destroyed multiple laptop batteries by relying on junk chargers.

users might need, such as an SD card slot for photographers or an Ethernet jack for gamers. You can always carry a [dongle](#) or [USB-C hub](#), but it can be extremely helpful to have these built in if you use them frequently.

Webcams, Hinges, and More



PHOTOGRAPH: LUKE LARSEN

We've discussed all the big-ticket items so far, but there's a lot more that makes up a laptop. These are do-it-all, lifestyle devices, and that means you'll likely use them in all sorts of scenarios.

majority of new laptops have finally moved the standard up to 1080p. Some models sometimes even push that up to 5 megapixels. The latest M5 MacBook Air, meanwhile, has a 12-megapixel webcam, pushing the envelope for camera quality on a laptop of this price.

How is the laptop's hinge? This part is hard to test if you're buying over the internet. If possible, head to a local store like Best Buy so you can hold the model you're interested in. Try opening it with one hand. That might sound silly, but trust me, not being able to open your laptop with one hand is annoying.

You should also consider the keyboard and trackpad quality. While keyboard quality is fairly consistent across laptops, trackpads can vary wildly. Haptic feedback trackpads have become more common on premium laptops, but even in mid-tier laptops, you'll want a glass surface with a click that isn't overly loud or difficult to press.

You might even consider the quality of the speakers if you plan to watch movies or listen to music frequently on the device. Laptop audio is usually awful. Most laptops have a very basic set of 5-watt stereo speakers, but four-speaker setups provide a richer, fuller sound. If you want better clarity and body in your sound, though, look for laptops that use a six-speaker setup for some extra oomph. The absolute best speaker system on a laptop is in the [16-inch MacBook Pro](#).

Make Your Choice



PHOTOGRAPH: CHRISTOPHER NULL

Once you've narrowed the field to a few models, read some reviews and look for things beyond the specifications, like how the hinge holds up over time, how the keyboard feels, how the trackpad performs, and even how hot the bottom gets in your lap. Reading reviews like those here at WIRED is helpful because looking at specs won't tell you whether a hinge is poorly made or feels sticky, or whether the lid scratches easily.

Technical perfection isn't everything, so don't ignore your idiosyncrasies. Do you want something that looks a certain way? There's nothing wrong with that. Some people hate the idea of a plastic shell. Others wouldn't be caught dead with anything other than black plastic. Design is important in both practical and aesthetic terms. It's no fun to use a laptop you don't like.

Where to Buy

The most difficult part of this whole process is finding exactly what you want. There is no perfect laptop store that's easy to navigate. It's always a bit of a challenge. You can buy straight from the manufacturer's website, or you can go with a major retailer.

Manufacturers' websites (like [HP](#), [Lenovo](#), [Microsoft](#), [Samsung](#), [Asus](#), and [Dell](#)) are sometimes overwhelming, especially when every possible configuration is listed separately, which nearly every manufacturer insists on doing. Many laptop retail sites use deceptive pricing practices, like Lenovo, which lists absurdly high "list" prices but sells everything at a perpetual discount. This is where it helps to shop around. Even if you end up buying from the manufacturer, be sure to check prices at stores like [Amazon](#), [Best Buy](#), [Newegg](#), and [B&H](#). Some brands have exclusive configurations only sold at specific retailers, so it's worth checking before pulling the trigger.

As you research, pay attention to details, and read through the specifications on each page to ensure you're comparing the model with 16 GB of RAM to another model with 16 GB of RAM, and so on. Look at warranties as well. It's nice to have a plan should something go wrong. The options vary widely based on where you buy your laptop, but I have used warranties from both Lenovo and Dell and have been satisfied with their service. (Use our [Dell coupon codes](#) to save on your next laptop.)

Power up with unlimited access to WIRED. Get best-in-class reporting and exclusive subscriber content that's too important to ignore. Subscribe Today.

- **In your inbox:** WIRED's most ambitious, future-defining stories
- AI slop backlash is actually having an impact
- **Big Story:** The cop who took on Flock
- The rise of the 1am job interview
- **Watch:** I stole a car by hacking this hidden device



Luke Larsen is a product writer and reviewer at WIRED, covering laptops, PCs, Macs, monitors, and the wider PC peripheral ecosystem. He's been reporting on tech for over a decade, previously at Digital Trends as the senior editor in computing, where he spent seven years leading the publication's daily coverage. ... [Read More](#)

PRODUCT WRITER & REVIEWER



Scott Gilbertson is Operations Manager for the WIRED Reviews Team. He was previously a writer and editor for WIRED's Webmonkey.com, covering the independent web and early internet culture. You can reach him at luxagraf.net. ... [Read More](#)

SENIOR WRITER AND REVIEWER



Hardwired to Find the Best of the Best

Upgrade your life with our *Gear* newsletter—get expert-tested product reviews, buying guides, deals, and how-to's.

SIGN UP

By signing up, you agree to our [user agreement](#) (including [class action waiver and arbitration provisions](#)), and acknowledge our [privacy policy](#).

READ MORE



FEATURED [BEST ALEXA SPEAKERS](#) [BEST KINDLES](#) [WATER LEAK DETECTORS](#) [BEST LAPTOP BACKPACK](#)

BOUTAYNA CHOKRANE



I Fixed a Tractor Using John Deere's Self-Repair Service. Farmers Aren't Sold on It

The agricultural machine manufacturer has a subscription service that lets owners repair their own equipment. Why is barely anybody using it?

BOONE ASHWORTH



'I'm Really Terrified': A Mathematician Grapples With AI's Recent Breakthroughs

Steven Strogatz coauthored a book about how math is moving beyond human understanding. He spoke with WIRED about the seismic impact artificial intelligence has had on his life's work.

ISABELLA WARD



laptop with efficient heat management.

LES SHU



Take Music Anywhere With These Tested Bluetooth Speakers

I tested portable speakers of all shapes and sizes, from pocket to party-sized.

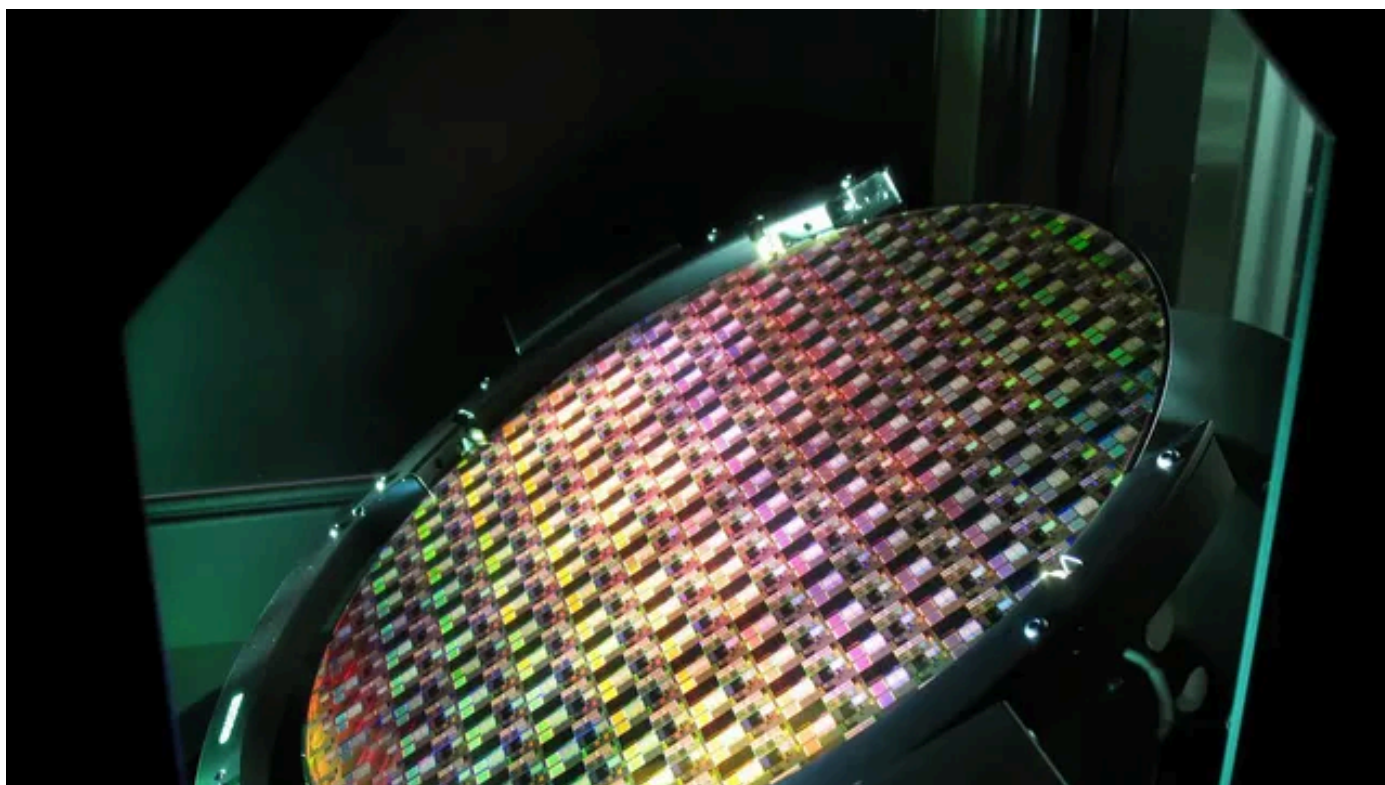
CHRIS HASLAM

[FEATURED](#)[BEST ALEXA SPEAKERS](#)[BEST KINDLES](#)[WATER LEAK DETECTORS](#)[BEST LAPTOP BACKPACK](#)

I'm Picky About Laptop Backpacks. These Are the Best I've Tested

The wrong bag can aggravate you every single day. These WIRED-tested picks get comfort, capacity, and organization just right.

KAT MERCK



LAUREN GOODE



There May Not Be an iPhone 18 This Year

Apple is expected to announce several products at its September event next week—including a folding phone—but the iPhone 18 might not be among them. It would be a first for the company.

BOONE ASHWORTH

WIRED COUPONS

Canon

CANON PROMO CODE

10% Off Canon Promo Code + Up to 30% Off

Verizon Home
Internet

VERIZON PROMO CODE

Best Verizon Smartphone Deals



VISTAPRINT PROMO CODE

vistaprint.

15% Off When You Buy Two With Vistaprint Coupon



PEACOCK PROMO CODE

Save With a Peacock Promo Code: 3 Months Free



SQUARESPACE

SQUARESPACE PROMO CODE

10% Off Exclusive Squarespace Promo Code 2026

